

MAYAWATI NEEDS TO DECIPHER IF HER 2007 ASSEMBLY WIN WAS THE RESULT OF HER MUCH-HYPED SOCIAL ENGINEERING OR WAS IT A SIMPLE ANTI-MULAYAM RAGE THAT WON HER THE STATE.

Even though powerful regional satraps had played their role in making things worse, the general secretary's leadership has been far from inspiring. Within the party, he inflated the Third Front account books and misled its middle-level leadership about certainty of the front forming the Government. His abilities as talent-spotter have now been doubted as allies like Mayawati and Chandrababu Naidu are nursing their bruises. Karat failed to turn his pitch against the nuclear deal into votes. Karat's adoption of many lies abandoned by history was not just instinctive. This time it was a case of his friends failing him. CPI(M) leaders privately admit that he is influenced by comrades of armchair variety. While many of the former general secretaries excelled as social commentators, Karat reduced himself as a policy wonk and a reluctant mediator in factional feuds.

The elections have diminished role of the Left nationally—even as a spectre that haunted Delhi's power centres. The Communist afterlife of the top comrade is also going to be risky. Soon after shameful defeat, Karat told journalists who asked about possible leadership change in Kerala, of course in complete jest: "Not in Kerala, may be in the Centre". Sentimentalism may not be a Marxist attribute, but Karat may surprise his Politburo colleagues by offering to resign. But this Karat line, unlike many of his other Marxist fetishes, can be inviting for at least some of his comrades.

by Shafi Rahman

MAYAWATI

Reality Bites

Uttar Pradesh *hui hamari, ab Dilli ki baari* (We have captured Uttar Pradesh. Now we will conquer Delhi). In the state, the ruling Bahujan Samajwadi Party's much-publicised slogan hangs in tatters. And Chief Minister Mayawati's dream of becoming the first Dalit prime minister lies broken after the outcome of the 2009 Lok Sabha elections. With the highest number of parliamentary constituencies, Uttar Pradesh is the golden road to power at the Centre. But the BSP supremo was in such a rush to reach Delhi that she compromised on her image, buried her ideology and that on which the BSP was founded in 1984. In the 2007 Assembly elections, the BSP had swept the state by winning 206 of the 403 seats, a feat unmatched in the last 20 years. Going by this, the BSP should have won at least 42 Lok Sabha seats, but has slithered to just 20, a far cry from the 55 seats it was hoping to win. The results reveal that the unprecedented mandate given to the BSP by the people has started

petering out in just two years. Mayawati herself wrote the BSP's epitaph in Uttar Pradesh, nursing her hangover for becoming the prime minister. During the vote of no-confidence on the nuclear deal issue, she joined hands with the Third Front in a failed attempt to dislodge the UPA Government and install herself in Manmohan Singh's chair. In the run-up to the general elections, she toured

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the country, neglecting her home state and wooing upper castes. In the past two years she created more foes than friends. To garner Brahmin votes, she recruited 13 dreaded mafia dons and fielded 48 candidates who had nothing to do with Dalit ideology. To Dalits, she sold the dream of choosing their first Dalit prime minister, but failed to grasp their resentment against her. Her social engineering failed as Brahmins returned to the BJP and Congress folds. Mayawati now needs to introspect; develop a second-line leadership, interact with grassroots cadres, focus on governance and development and keep a golden eye on her core constituency. Failing this, the BSP may once again slip into the old days of being a marginal political player.

by Subhash Mishra